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Larry Gold

Musician, arranger, and composer Larry Gold has played an integral role in multiple genres of music. His collaboration skills and progressive thinking enabled him to guide hit-making artists from the Philly Sound to current hip hop artists.

Larry was interviewed via Zoom on June 18, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive, and I'm very pleased to have Larry Gold with me today, musician, arranger, composer, studio owner, and I'm going to describe you as the musical glue in a long line of hit records.

LG: I'll take that.

MR: You'll take that.

LG: I'll take that.

MR: Okay. I'm trying to think of an anecdote, oh yes, this is a little odd. I've been watching re—runs of "The Sopranos."

LG: Me too. I just finished as a matter of fact and it's like — it's my second time without my wife to watch it. And what I do is I actually play the cello — I know the dialogue a lot now so I will play scales and I'll play, you know I'm like working on a few new pieces. My hands hurt. But I'm trying my best you know, with my time, you know I make myself work on music for three or four hours a day no matter what the day may entail like I did when I was little. I mean, you know,

MR: There was character called Christopher, you know Christopher, and there's one session/episode where —

LG: He mentions the "Philly Sound."

MR: Yeah. He mentions the Philly Sound and he was like, "Well I know music —" blah blah blah, and he mentions the Philly Sound.

LG: Well actually what he says was, "The mob's been tied in to the record business forever and he starts mentioning certain names and everything and then he throws in the Philly Sound, which believe it or not, and I'm not going to say it, but the only mob activity the Philly Sound had was via Columbia Records.

MR: That's priceless. I don't want to go too far back because we have to end up in the present but I brought in a couple of props today, thinking about your writing, when it occurred and here's my first prop. Score pads.

LG: Yeah. I still have them right here.

MR: Yeah. Did you — you started out that way? Pen and pencil I would imagine?

LG: Absolutely.

MR: Yeah.

LG: Well I went to Curtis so I grew up writing. You know we used to have to imitate Bach chorales and things like that so I was very familiar. But then that whole pop music scene in Philadelphia in the '60s and '70s overwhelmingly fascinated me. You know I mean because they were kids who grew up in my neighborhood after the great songwriters and the great arrangers and the great everybody and it just fascinated me. I went a little different left, I went to Curtis as a cello player but yet participated in Cameo and Parkway and the early Gamble records, and all those early records from I would say from age 14 — 13, 14 on.

MR: I don't want to make too much out of this but it seems to me when you were making this decision at 17 according to your promo here, that you had one foot in the white world of music and you had another in the black world of music. Were you aware of that? Was that partly your decision to go — to leave Curtis and go in this other direction?

LG: Well you know at that moment it was the hippie days so I was playing in a few bands. The bands were based on blues. Blues obviously the derivative of blues is black music, the church the old work songs, every — all that. You know? So yeah I was fascinated. I was also fascinated by popular music in general. But in Philadelphia the people that were really adept that I met were people like Leon Huff and people like, you know they were Tommy Bell and they were really crazily talented people that weren't talented like the fiddle players at Curtis, like the violinists at Curtis, but in a whole different way off the top of their head and involving the black church and a lot of things. It was fascinating. Plus I grew up in a very poor neighborhood. My father had a hardware toy store in North Philly, which was a very mixed neighborhood to begin with. So yes I knew that I had, in those days I don't think today — if you're a classical musician, you go to Juilliard, you can come out and frame your classical background or your jazz background in a whole lot of different light than you used to be able to in the '60s. It's a different world today than it was then. You either had to go one route, the long hair route, which was classical music or you had to go the other route which was almost giving that up. Curtis hated that I used to play at the Latin Casino to make a buck. You know? I mean in those days if I made a few hundred dollars a week that was amazing. I could live forever on it.

MR: Playing the bass, right?

LG: Cello.

MR: Playing the cello.

LG: In the string section.

MR: In the string sections. Okay. But you became a bass player.

LG: I did play bass too, and I played guitar too. But I gave them up when, in the '70s, when the '70s really started rolling and I started arranging and making records and doing all that stuff I didn't play the bass anymore. I barely played the cello anymore.

MR: On average, when you were hired to write string charts, can you describe the tracks that were given to you? Did it have the vocals on it usually or was it just the basic rhythm section?

LG: It had a rhythm section and vocals. Almost 95% of the time it had vocals and a rhythm section. Every once in a while it might not have had backgrounds on it but a lot of them before the arranger got the record they were almost finished.

MR: Which is a challenge in itself, isn't it? The ability to know what not to write as well as what to write.

LG: You just hit the nail on the head as we say. The thing is is that when a record is almost done there's not much room for you to overwrite. I mean you really have to pick your spots. And in my whole life, all these sixty years I'm picking my spots. You know? Yeah. I mean, and I have the tendency to be in a more simple way than a lot of other arrangers. I don't like over—do things. I like things to be poignant and emotional, you know. If it's a great R&B record I like to make it an R&B opera. You know? Give it that background where the height of the record hits its peak and then trails off and does its thing.

MR: What's your preferred string section? If you have a decent budget do you like — how many violins violas, etcetera?

LG: Well it all depends. In the old days I had six violins, two violas, and two cellos, which I still do a lot today. And much against union rules, I double that. And even back in the '70s and the '60s I used to double that. So, and that to me, if I get a couple of great performances that's plenty.

MR: Did your string players, when you were overdubbing and doubling did they like to hear what they just played in their headphones?

LG: Sometimes yes, some of them would, and sometimes no.

MR: Okay.

LG: You know when I first started playing on records we didn't even have earphones. We used little speakers. There was a speaker in the room and everybody just could hear each other. And then I guess when we doubled it they reversed the phase on or something

somehow they canceled out the speaker. And the speaker couldn't be really loud so there was usually one speaker in front of the cellos and violas and maybe one speaker to the side of the violins, and maybe one to the other side. And that was the way, all through the '60s that's how we did it in Philadelphia.

MR: It must have contributed, even marginally to the sound of those records because you're recording the room on the overdub even though you might have been trying to avoid it, you're still getting that.

LG: I think you're right, you know I think you're right. You know Phil Ramone came down late '70s one time to record something. And I was playing that time, and I even think I helped him get the section together. And he said, he couldn't believe how small Sigma was. The ceilings weren't very high. The room dimension was really small. He was used to big rooms you know. I mean but he was amazed that Joe Tarsia got that great sound from such a small room.

MR: I thought of a comment. Recently I interviewed Alan Broadbent and I asked him what it was like the very first time you write something and you hear it played. And he described it as a "cringe moment." Because you never quite now how it's going to lay until they really start to play it.

LG: Well especially in the '70s and the '80s before we had all these computers. Now I can do a little dubbing, I have a Synclavier so I can put the song in my Synclavier and do a little sketch and I can listen to it. It's not the same at all but at least I can hear — I can play with the voicing. I can play with a lot of different things. You know I start editing out things more than I do adding.

MR: I saw a video just earlier today of you and I said, "What is that keyboard in the background?" And that's probably what it was.

LG: It's a Synclavier, yeah.

MR: Yeah. It's got a lot of dials and buttons.

LG: It works. It's worked since 1983.

MR: Okay. This is my other prop, speaking of 1983.

LG: Oh yeah.

MR: These things were heavy.

LG: That's a big reel too. Usually they weren't quite that big. That's almost double the amount of tape. Usually they were half that size but that wide. Yeah I mean, hey look, those days were special in lots and lots of different ways because a lot of that stuff was just being invented in a way too. It went from everyone recording live when I was a little boy in like '63 or '62. You used to have to go to another tape recorder to overdub. You would take what you had recorded on one tape recorder and do the orchestration to another tape

recorder, and maybe do that for the vocals and then all of a sudden your finished record had a couple generations worth of moving from one tape recorder to another.

MR: Like The Beatles did.

LG: Like The Beatles did. And this was prior to them doing that.

MR: Did you find that — this is an observation again but playing the cello and then being at Curtis in ensembles, I'm guessing it must have paid off really well when you started arranging and composing, not only for the strings but just observing brass players and knowing what's capable, what's going to make them sound the best where to breathe etcetera.

LG: You know I'm going to give you a little secret here. I was part of that Philly Sound. And what I did originally when I was little — when I was little — in my 20s I learned how these great older arrangers wrote for the MFSB which was the orchestra in Philadelphia at that time. So a lot of my initial stuff was not only my Curtis background but it was sitting there playing and listening to what they had done for the last eight years or so. And so yes it became second—hand, it became really easy for me to write because I knew what was sort of expected of the sounds of those instruments and what was expected on records. It's like you said, how do you finish a record? How do you put a proper arrangement on a record that's going to work?

MR: Some of that is not answerable. That's what I think makes it so wonderful is that you can't pin down why things work or why some particular record that you might not even anticipate becomes a hit.

LG: Absolutely not. But you know what a good song is, and you also know that you're not stepping on the vocalist. And you know that you're adding to the dimension of the record. That's all. But you're right. And there's no one way of doing it. There are many ways to do it.

MR: I sometimes think of music — when you're switching radio stations for instance — you're listening to something from '58, '64, into the hip hop era. And if music was a pie chart, if the audio — to me it used to be that the vocal had the biggest slice of the pie. Now I hear bass as like the predominant thing that people hear.

LG: Well you know what? I think it's — the record business, if you're really into the record business, is really created about through the inventions of all the technology. And what happened back in those days you couldn't really get bass to really respond enormously on the radio speaker or on these little speakers that we had. And then as — when we went to the movie theater we got bass because they had those big Voice of Music speakers that were this big. When we went to the studio we got bass because those were the same speakers that were there too. But people didn't have them in their homes. Now they've got

little speakers this big you have so much bass coming out of it it's incredible. So I think, and then I think that one of the things about bass — be it synth bass or regular bass — it makes the record have a lot more volume and power. So I think that's partially a lot of the reason.

MR: I've always felt the basses can be the most important thing happening because it acts like a drum, it guides the harmony, and it takes a certain mindset to be a good and appropriate bass player.

LG: I agree. And I agree it's one of the most important things. You know when I still get a chance to produce a whole record, when I hire — to me the bass player is the most important person I'm hiring. Because he'll drive the record, especially if it's R&B or disco or any of the kind of things that I get hired to do at this point in my life.

MR: I pulled a quote off a shorter video that I saw of you, and you were in the studio looking at older equipment and you said, "I was hands—on back when the needs were small."

LG: Yeah.

MR: Do you remember saying that?

LG: Absolutely.

MR: Can you expand on that?

LG: Well as I just said before this record business and the film business is based on technology. So what happens is things keep getting bigger, more complicated, it's just big. My first Neve I had was 15 channels. About this big. It was an old broadcast board. That was amazing, that I could line everything patch everything into and have everything come out of and I had a 24—track in my room in those days. Originally I had an 8—track. Okay? But eventually I had a 24—track in the room. And even though I didn't have 24 channels — I think I only had 16 — I was able to accommodate. You know? I would have the drums on a mix and I'd have this on that and everything. And it was manageable for me. I could get a record to sound the way I wanted to in my little room. Now did that translate out into the real world? I always had a professional engineer come in and mix them anyway. I did. But yes, it was much more manageable. And I still have that — well I don't have it — I sold the studio so the people who bought my studio, they still have that old Neve broadcast board.

MR: How — in current technology where basically you have unlimited tracks and capabilities and moving things and splicing out a quarter note, is it harder to know when a song is done?

LG: Oh yeah. Yeah you want to keep working on it. It's like, it becomes an obsession. As a matter of fact one of the things that for the last twenty years I've had the same engineer doing my strings for me and my horns for me. And a lot of times when I'm finished I

don't stay in the room. I let him finish it himself. Because his ears bring it to a different place than me futzing with it all the time.

MR: Very interesting. I watched the other, this was fascinating you were in Berlin, 2018 I think, and it was a video of working with a string section and it looked like it was the first read through of what you had — I think you wrote the chart.

LG: I didn't write the chart. I remember it.

MR: Okay. I wonder then, because of some things you said but here's a couple of comments you made during that session to the string players. First of all, "You've got to wait." They kept coming in early on like the and of four or something, and then you said, "don't overplay" because they were just I guess really getting into it. And then you said I thought significantly, "you don't need that."

LG: Yeah. I edited his arrangement. I went in to the control room and asked them if I could. Because they had over—written it you know? And I sort of edited it. And the string players, you know if you stayed there for an hour or two hours they would have gotten it even the way he wrote it. But the thing is why? You know? It was not necessary. So I very kindly asked him if I could edit. And he consented that. Yeah. But yeah I mean I really — you have all these microphones and you have all these things, I mean it's good to play forte all the time and show me how you can play, but the thing is is I'm more interested in the mood of the record and how the record sounds, and how the violin sounds. You know when I — or how the cello sounds. You know? I mean when I feel myself pressing either on the cello I don't like it. You know it's a tight sound. It's not an open sound. And I like an open sound. I like things to have an openness to them, in the same way that I — when I write chords I like open chords. I like — I don't like dense things. I like more things that are — it depends on the song but most of the time I like more of an open voicing.

MR: Define — what is your version of open voicing?

LG: My version of open voicing is almost like a string quartet. So the cello has a note, the viola has a note and the violin might have two notes or maybe three notes. It's not like eight notes. I mean there are arrangers that come in and I — the violins are stacked you know. And it's not — I'm not saying it's bad, it's just not the way I write.

MR: Like a little air in there.

LG: Big time. More than a little.

MR: I think it's interesting that you talk about volume and playing really hard because you could say well play as loud as you want, we'll just pull the bar down of your volume but that's not how it works. You're still going to get loud playing softer.

LG: Right. It's not the way these mics are perceived or even the way — you know one of the things about great vocalists you know they might be belters you know but they'll entice you into a song. They don't start out belting. Or some of them don't, I mean Aretha sometimes did and some of these other young people like Jennifer Hudson does sometimes. But — [there's a little traffic out here, I'm sorry]. But it's more like you're telling a story and even with your voice you're telling a story. And even with the violin or the cello or the arrangement or the record, you know it's like I remember a lot of these hip hop kids when they started coming to me in the late '90s and the middle '90s whenever it started, that big wave that I had there for a while. You know they would say after I finished an arrangement they'd say, "Man, you were like telling a story with the strings." They were the one telling the story, all I was doing was following their arc.

MR: Following their arc. I like that.

LG: You know and even though a lot of the hip hop records started the same and ended the same, there was always like a vocal arc. You know even the rapper had to breathe. Or on some of those records the singing came into the choruses. But I would always try to follow the arc of the song, which is what I did when I was a little kid. So to me I remember you know I mean maybe I cared too much about it but I really don't think I did. I think that part of my success within the frame of hip hop was because that's what I did.

MR: I'm not sure what you mean, that's what you did?

LG: I told the story with the arrangement in a way as they were telling a story, depending on what — I didn't care who it was. It could be, you know The Roots or anybody. I mean I told the story. They were telling a story and I did too. So it wasn't just the same line that came in and that's what the arranging on popular music became that. It became very similar. You'd write a line for the chorus and it came in every time.

MR: Yeah and they wouldn't even have to play it again, we'll just like move it over there. When you were working with Gamble and Huff and Thom Bell, I'm trying to frame this idea. Before someone coined the term the Philly Sound, was there a speculation or conversations about what is Motown not doing that we could do? How can we find a niche in the market?

LG: You know I think the big difference between Motown and Philly Sound was Motown was the sound of the young America. It was really a youth movement. R&B. Whereas the Philly sound was a sophisticated, much jazzier much more adult kind of a sound. I mean I've always thought that MFSB could have been the Lionel Hampton band. You know? And in turn, in a way, I was right. MFSB could have gone and played behind Frank Sinatra or anybody. You know? I mean it was that adept at a lot of different styles and adult styles. And I also think that, I also think Gamble, Huff and Bell, they grew up I

mean I think Tommy Bell was enamored with Burt Bacharach. And Burt Bacharach was very sophisticated you know? And I think a lot of Thom's arrangements back in those days were like Bacharach arrangements. They would feature a horn player or feature a flute or feature — I mean feature a harp. I mean he had his way of introducing symphonic instruments. And in the '70s, early '70s, that was a big deal I think.

MR: Who was he writing for previous to this? Do you know?

LG: I think that he was — I think that the main rhythm section of the Philly Sound used to work at a place called The Uptown, which was the place where all the Motown groups and all the southern groups would come in and they were the rhythm section. So they were a back—up rhythm section and I think Thom was — played piano in a whole bunch of different kinds of groups. I think as an early 20—year—old, but I think he started having hits pretty soon after that.

MR: Do you know if he was a quote schooled musician?

LG: He definitely went to — he went to some education yes. He had some musical education. There was a place in Philadelphia called the Combs College of Music, that was up in one of the urban neighborhoods in Philadelphia. And I think he took classes there. You know this is before, now every college has courses. You know that. I mean I have nothing to do with any universities at all but every college teaches engineering and teaches music and — in those days that wasn't the case.

MR: Whoever wrote this promo on your website spoke about them saying, "They also had a brilliant ability to figure out what the people wanted to hear. The result? The sound of Philadelphia." How did they figure out what people wanted to hear?

LG: Well I used to say they had the pulse. They had the beat and pulse of the neighborhoods if that makes sense. In a way it's like jazz. You know they had the beat and pulse of the neighborhoods. So to me that — my phrase that they knew what people wanted to hear, that's what I mean. And also I think if you go back and pick song to song there was a lot of like how do you say this, there was a lot of over—emotional songs that Gamble used to write. He was quite a hell of a lyricist. And some of those songs, "Me and Mrs. Jones," Billy Paul and I mean I can go on and on, but then he had another side to him where it was so commercial like "Love Train." You know that was, it was almost like what do they call those songs candy apple? I don't know the term they use in popular music.

MR: Bubble gum.

LG: But you know they're teenybops. You know they're like —

MR: Yeah. Bubble gum rock.

LG: Yeah. And Tommy Bell "La—la Means I Love You." You know? I mean just the title alone is enough to make you go oh my God. You know I remember in the early '70s my

wife and I were staying in New York one night. And we went into the elevator and there was an arrangement of "La—la Means I Love You." You know? Done by Muzak. And I thought to myself, "Shit this is going to really be big."

MR: Yes if it's attracting that, those delivery system, that's a big tell. They also seem not to be afraid to write social commentary.

LG: Big time.

MR: Yeah. Like "Wake Up Everybody" with Harold Melvin and —

LG: Well "Wake Up Everybody" was written by my good friend John Whitehead. That was not a Gamble song. That was McFadden and Whitehead. And John Whitehead and I were friends until he died until he got shot here in the city. But he wrote "Ain't No Stopping Us Now" which is another really big, sort of political song. And he wrote "Back Stabbers," that's a really political song. You know? I mean he was a character that kid. He was a real natural talent.

MR: There was no discussion — or was there — about gee, this is, we can't really release this song this is too controversial?

LG: Not for them. They were always on — black music in those days was always on the left anyway. It was never mainstream, you know? It became mainstream, you know, I mean it really did. You know by the middle '70s and the late '70s it was very mainstream to the point where MFSB went and played the White House one time, when Jimmy Carter was president. So you know Teddy Pendergrass playing the White House? You know? I mean singing at the White House? That's a little weird you know, in the '70s.

MR: Indeed. It seems that technology and hip hop seem to go hand—in—hand with the production values. I wonder if you as a musician yourself was a bit surprised when melodic content became not necessary?

LG: Yeah. But it was a slow ball. It wasn't like it was a fast ball. It started like in the early '80s. Late '70s already you had like the early rap songs coming out. So I knew, and then there were the DJs on the radio that all they all rhymed. Remember the old DJs? I mean the R&B DJs? They were all like poets and didn't know it. Look at Muhammad Ali. Muhammad Ali came out of that same school. Everything was a rhyme. Everything was a phrase that you could remember. So that didn't surprise me, especially being a student of black culture and black music, which I pride myself in those days. It's hard to keep up these days, at age 77. It is. I almost like want to throw my hands up a little bit. But back in those days I definitely, even in the early '80s you know there were a lot of early hip hop records that my partner and I, we worked on behind the scenes, nobody even knew.

MR: Huh. What makes you keep going?

LG: I like working, I like music, I like — been doing this since I was a little boy. It's the thing I do best actually I think. I think at this point I do this better than playing the cello even though at one time I think I played the cello better than I did this. So I think what happened was they got reversed. And I'm always fascinated, like this year I guess I can say I did a really nice song with Ed Sheeran that'll come out in September. It's like sort of like a wedding song in an R&B style and it was a good song. And I did another really nice song with — I did a couple of other songs, I can't even remember — well Bruno Mars, you know I mean I'm not even supposed to say that out loud because I signed these agreements that I'm not allowed to even talk about it. But you know these kids, some of them are really super talented songwriters, as good as all the people I used to grow up with.

MR: I read a quote from let's see, who said it — Fred Wesley, when I spoke to him. He said this phrase probably six times in the interview talking about writing for James Brown he said, "I didn't know what I was doing." And he kept saying it, like — and I felt like saying, "Well yes you did." But have you ever been in a situation early on that you didn't feel like you knew what you were doing?

LG: Absolutely. You learn on the job. That's what Fred means. But Fred was a great player. And he knew all about that stuff, he had grown up listening to those records. Come on. You know? But yeah I mean my early on I would look for — I would wait for Tommy Bell to smile or Gamble & Huff to say damn that's nice or McFadden and Whitehead to come in and start dancing in the studio in front of the strings. You know? All of a sudden I said, "I take it you like it." They said, "Yeah we do." I mean Whitehead used to call me the Golden Child.

MR: Well you had no issues being accepted into that if it was a circle, but I'll call it a circle?

LG: You know I got to, as the years went on I got more and more accepted into it. You know Kenny Gamble, I've seen him like recently and he said "Boy I wish I would have known how talented you were when we were kids." Because he thought I was just a cello player in one way. But then as the years went on he saw, and then he used to come to my studio, you know, and in one way, and then when you know his son — his son came and worked for me for a little while. Kenny called me up and said he didn't have a studio and he wasn't really into everyday record business, and he said, "My son's dying to work for someone who makes records all the time." And he came and he worked as an assistant engineer. In those days we used to have — you had to EQ the tape recorders, you had to align the tape recorders, you had to do — you know we tried to teach Caliph how to do all that and he was real happy being here. And Kenny just expressed to me the fact that he wished that he would have known the breadth of my talents back in those days. But

you know what? I was a shy person in a way. You know I didn't want to — I did open my mouth too much. I have to say, I wasn't that shy. But I didn't want to overstep my bounds in my relationship with Gamble, Huff and Bell.

MR: Did you ever work with Bernard Purdie?

LG: I worked on records that he played on, but I don't think I ever worked with him, no.

MR: Okay. The only reason I asked is you were talking about, you know, opening your mouth maybe too often which he basically admitted to. When you —

LG: I did — early on in the Sound of Philadelphia I would correct some of the string parts, I would if there was a wrong note here or — do this. Or tell people that, you know like you saw me do it in Berlin. I did that since I was a little boy.

MR: I was impressed by that because not only your comments but it looked to me like those string players were very flexible because you'd say something like, "Extend that quarter note" and like I didn't see anybody frantically grabbing a pencil and, you know, it's like they were absorbing what you were saying.

LG: Well you know after you play a song down a few times some people grab pencils and other people can remember.

MR: Yeah. Okay.

LG: So I mean different strokes for different folks.

MR: Do you find that you are working on assignments even when you're not working? You go for a walk and you've still got this —

LG: Oh yeah yeah. Especially when over the years of my lifetime I used to do my best writing when I took my power walk in the morning. You know? I would hear the song and I'd start finishing it — I'd come home, I'd grab a piece of paper and I'd start correcting what I had in my head or where I had left it the day before. Absolutely. I never thought a song was finished until I could hear it in my head completely be it in bed in the morning or, you know, I would feel much better about my arrangement if I had it that rote in me, you know, if it was that big a part of me at that moment.

MR: What do you send in what form is your music in when you send it to your copyist?

LG: A couple of different ways either written, either written out on the score paper, or I've used one guy who has perfect pitch and he can take my arrangement and I separate — I do the violins on the left, the violas on the right and the cello in the middle. And you know from my Synclavier he writes out my arrangements and sends me a fair copy and then I take the fair copy and I re—work that with a pencil and I work on that for a couple of days and then I call him up on Zoom and I say here are my changes and it's done.

MR: I think it's really cool that you — a Synclavier goes back how many years now?

LG: 42.

MR: And it's still useful for you.

LG: Big time.

MR: Yeah.

LG: Big time. Yeah I mean it's not state—of—the—art sound—wise at this point, you know, the way I have it. But as far as my memory and it's like a big tape recorder that I can work on parts of the song. You can do that now with computers but who wants to look at a screen all day long? I don't want to look at a screen all day long, I hate looking at the phone as much as we look at the phone these days. You know? I mean I find myself reading the paper on the phone, and then later I'll play a crossword on the phone. I mean you end up doing so much on the phone. Whereas the Synclavier, it's like a digital tape recorder. So I can spot the different spots of the song, and like I said I can sit here and listen to it. You know? I'm not saying that I don't — I have my score paper right here and a lot of times my best ideas I write at home and bring them in and then I put them in the Synclavier and listen to them. But I've grown lazy over the course of my lifetime.

MR: Here's an odd question: do you have a favorite dissonance that you employ on occasion? Or color tones that work well with strings?

LG: Well in R&B I would say that they would only be the sevenths and the ninths or the elevenths. You know? I mean so it's like you're always looking for that magic note that goes well with the vocal, not per se with — even though the chord has to allow you to do that, but I think the altered chords, which we used to call, at Curtis they were altered chords okay? But they're not any more in life called that. But I think they're part of what the appetite right now is still in R&B.

MR: If you're writing for a woman as opposed to a man, is there a tendency — well let me rephrase — a guy's voice is going to be an octave lower than a woman singing the same melody. Does it affect the range that you write in, depending?

LG: Absolutely. Yeah I mean the tendency is to give him that space, whereas on a female voice I have all the bottom that I can use and on a male voice I tend to maybe like spread it out a little bit more so that I don't get in his way. But sometimes I do. Sometimes I like to get in the way and rub a little bit. You know? I think that's part of it. And I even think like you know like a lot of the hip hop records that I've done, you know I like doing that. Because I don't think if I bring in high things, sometimes it's inappropriate for the record. So I'm always looking for a way of saying something within the context of the record more than the context of male or female vocals.

MR: Do you like to have a separate lyric sheet to read?

LG: I never get that. But I sometimes will write out the lyric sheet.

MR: Oh.

LG: Nobody ever sends me lyrics.

MR: No kidding? I don't know if something —

LG: They don't even send me a lead sheet. Most of these kids can't do that you know. You know we create our own lead sheet. That's one of the first things I do is somehow I give myself a lead sheet and I write down the important words on the lead sheet so I know where I am at in the song and I know where — yeah — I do that myself.

MR: Okay. It really makes you own the song I think, to go to that extra work and do it yourself. It sort of really gets it implanted in your head.

LG: Yeah that's the whole point to do it is like but even when I was a little boy to learn a concerto or something until it was in my head I didn't know it. You've got to memorize, like right now I'm re—learning the fourth Bach Suite cello—wise. So I've been working on the prelude a lot this week and I almost have the whole thing memorized now for the second or third time in my lifetime.

MR: Is it harder to play now than it was when you were 17?

LG: Oh my God no comparison. My hands hurt, and my bow arm's nowhere near as good. But you know there was a period of time when I didn't really play every day all the time. So it's like I can't expect — I gave that up to have a different kind of career. And I would say from the late '70s I really didn't play until you know maybe there were probably about 25—30 years that I didn't play even on a day to day level. You know? I ran a studio, I had employees, I tried to hustle. In the '80s I made a lot of what I call youth R&B records. The '80s were very popular, the kids singing. So I made a record with a 14—year—old or a 16—year—old group or a 17—year. You know? I mean and it involved a lot of hours and you were exhausted just pulling teeth and getting the records done on time and making them try to be good.

MR: Yeah. When you did these animated film scores, how do you start? Do you get a synopsis first or do you get sort of a completed animated film?

LG: Na. Never.

MR: Never. Okay.

LG: I always got a storyboard that a lot of times would designate timing. So I would know how long the scene was and sometimes I would get dialogue you know, sometimes you know if the animator would start, we would start with the dialogue. So I would use the dialogue as my — and it was all done with score paper. That was back in the day before computers and it was all done with score paper. And I would write out the dialogue or I'd write out where I wanted things to hit or, you know, and I learned how to, in those days I was always fascinated by the equipment too. I mean I remember — my wife will tell you that in one house I had an 8—track Scully in the basement. You know? I mean I was

always fascinated by the equipment so I learned how to do — what did they call it — Mag film rolls, you know, so that I had you know when you do an animated film you might have the dialogue on one strip and then you have sound effects on another strip, you have music on another strip, and then you have the picture on another strip. And you have control over — hand-cranked — that's the way we did it. So a lot of times I would write to it that way. You know? I would fit the music in — after I wrote it I would — I learned how to use it. I would actually copy it on Mag film and splice it in and if I didn't like some of the things I'd re—splice. I learned how to cut tape in other words.

MR: That was my next question. The first time you took a razor blade to tape —

LG: I was a kid.

MR: Yeah.

LG: I was a kid. I remember being in my mom's house when I was little and my dad bought me a Webcor portable tape recorder. It was the first one that could sit like this on a desk. I mean it wasn't gigantic, it was just like this. And it had reel—to—reel. And I remember I played the cello and then I turned it around the other thing and I tried to play another cello part and it was delayed obviously. I couldn't figure that out yet because that was — those guys were moving the heads and they were figuring how to time delay multi—track recording and stuff. I didn't know that. But I would take a razor blade and I would cut. And I had editing tape. And I enjoyed it. I actually liked it. You know playing the cello was hard. And this was not as hard in a way but it was really enjoyable. And then playing the cello was a solitary thing. You went in a room and you practiced for hours and hours and hours to get good, by yourself. You went to visit your professor once a week, or you played chamber music once a week, orchestra twice a week. So what is that, a grand total of twelve hours? Making a film with a great writer and a great animator and a great voiceover narrator and all that stuff, it was a group of people in the booth. It was like playing quartets all the time. I mean I enjoyed the camaraderie. And I loved that about making rhythm & blues records too. You know not that I was like them because I wasn't like them. I was a cello player from Kensington with my own life. But did I enjoy my time spent with them? I loved it. You know and one of the things I have to say in the early '70s, I loved smoking reefer and they smoked reefer too so in a way my classical musicians no one smoked reefer in those days, very few people did. But the jazz musicians and the R&B musicians they did.

MR: Did you use mostly jazz horn players?

LG: They were all jazz. Very few were — I mean there might have been one bone player who went to Curtis with me, or before me that was in that. And then the French horn player he

could play jazz though. You know? But yeah they were all jazz players. And all the great arrangers were jazz players in those days. I was an anomaly and still am in a way.

MR: It seems that jazz players need less instruction, or they need less ink. Like they hear what's needed, how to phrase things, and from their years, you know some of them in the big band — came from the big bands and so forth.

LG: Most of them did.

MR: Yeah.

LG: Gamble's number one arranger was I think from Lionel Hampton.

MR: Cool.

LG: A vibe player.

MR: Do you know Joel Dorn? Did you know Joel Dorn?

LG: I grew up with his brother, John Dorn, who was a tuba player. And then John I think went to Curtis too for a little while and then John Dorn ended up playing with Leon Redbone. Remember Leon Redbone?

MR: Yes.

LG: Remember he had a tuba player and a banjo player?

MR: Yes.

LG: Joel's brother John played tuba for Leon. But I met John in the '80s through somebody else that I was making records for. And then he died shortly thereafter so I really didn't know him that well but I met him quite a few times during the '80s.

MR: Well the reason I brought it up is I asked him, now this goes back a number of years, but I asked him, because he worked for Atlantic and then he had his own labels. And we were taking about the different delivery system now, from LPs to where things are at now and if it mattered to him. And he goes, "Naa I don't care. I just make the product and whatever they do with it —" so do you care?

LG: I don't care but in one way I'm not — I don't understand it a lot anymore. You know? I mean I have a subscription for Apple Music. So if I want to hear a song I put the name of the song in, I can hear it. Okay. So I guess that's how people make their living, you know? Through usage. But people are always complaining that they don't get paid enough from Spotify and they don't get paid enough for this or that or that or this. So it's a little confusing.

MR: Yeah. Well I'm going to wrap up —

LG: Also the fact that there's so many home studios and everyone who makes a record they are like I don't know, I think, you can look this up, I might be wrong but there are thousands and thousands of records released every day. That was not the case when John and I grew up.

MR: Yeah. It's a little less special.

LG: Big time. Big time. And then it seems like one of the great things about the old record labels was they were really looking for — like I read an article recently about John Hammond, who I never knew was related to the Vanderbilts you know. I mean I had known his son, who was a great guitar player John Hammond Jr. In the '60s I met him. But I mean John Hammond, if you list the names of the people that he found and that recorded, they were all brilliant. They were so talented. It doesn't seem like you could make a living in those days unless you were pretty good.

MR: I'm going to quote you on that. That's a good one.

LG: You know well I don't know whether it's true, sir but I definitely have a feeling like that. It's like even among the hip hop community there were some kids that were so overtly talented that you knew they were going to do well when I met them as kids. Because they were like open books. They were like jazz musicians in their own way. They really loved music, they loved assembly, they loved putting things together, they liked the rhythm of the whole event. And yeah I mean in one way it's really good, the fact that people can make records in their house because it's more creative for the people but then it's less creative because then there's a lot less people playing and learning instruments. And I mean I don't know where this balance goes and I don't know —

MR: And where does it end?

LG: And where does it end? I don't know. And you're archiving the whole thing, which is great. So anybody who's interested can go back and look at all these great musicians and composers and arrangers and I don't know are you doing singers too? You're doing everything? Yeah. So that's wonderful. You know? I mean because at least if a kid is interested in learning they'll have something to go and listen to. You know you should put it up — do you have an internet channel that you have them on?

MR: We do. It's called Fillius Jazz and there's 500 sessions up there.

LG: There you go.

MR: You'll be — I think it's 504 or so.

LG: There you go. So you know they have something they can go look, if they find a name that all of a sudden if they find Bernard Purdie, oh, what's up, he invented a shuffle? Oh let me go put his name in. And then they can get a hit off of that. You know what I mean? It's like that's important stuff. It's like that makes this as respectful as classical music was. You know? Where I read something recently about the history of the cello. You know that was written like 75 years ago. You know? And it was fascinating to me. You know? But I'm a cellist so it would be fascinating. But I still took the energy to read it.

MR: Here's a little — why this just occurred to me — the baritone saxophone and the cello, especially a baritone saxophone with a low A and the cello are like this. They have the same range and I had a student here who played one of the Bach unaccompanied cello suites on the baritone saxophone. It was awesome except there's no place to breathe.

LG: That's the problem. Even, I don't know you should — what did he play the first one? I mean do you remember which suite it was?

MR: Yeah she played the first one.

LG: Well she should do a little more research. Because the first one there's one where they say the legato goes all the way through the whole measure. And then there's one where they say the legato goes halfway. So you can actually play it [scats] so you can breathe within that context. So like I said there are all different ways of stroking the kitty. You know? But I admire that. I remember — do you know the name of a bass player named Anthony Jackson?

MR: Yes indeed.

LG: Very great jazz bass player. He grew up in Philadelphia and he actually wrote "Money Money, Money." He did that bass line with Gamble & Huff. If you go back, I'll bet he made more money from that song than he made from anything in his entire life. Gamble & Huff gave him a piece of the song, because he came up with that [scats] — whatever it was, I can't remember it and I can't sing it exactly. But one morning I came in to the studio and he was there and I hear [scats]. He was practicing the first Bach suite. This was like 1973. I looked at him and I said, "Man." He said "I love it."

MR: That's great. This has really been a fascinating chat. And I wanted to ask you two things that I read and we'll wrap it up. It said that you used to cut school to go watch Elvis Presley movies.

LG: Loved him. Learned how to play the guitar as a kid, a real kid dirt young. And I learned how to — my mother used to say in that rough neighborhood where we grew up, she used to say, "You could go into a bar and probably make more money than I made in the store today."

MR: Yes it reminds me of some of the guys that played in the Depression. Eddie [Billy] Bauer talked about making, you know 40 bucks a week when his father was making 8.

LG: That's right. My father used to call me "the Baron."

MR: Wow.

LG: When I would have a few sessions in the week at age 13 or 14. And I'd come home in a herringbone coat because Curtis you had to dress up for anyway. You had to wear a suit and tie at Curtis. So but yeah, my dad at one time called me "the Baron."

MR: Yeah.

LG: But when they saw that I built this studio my mother went, "Oy my God." She plotzed. She said, "Isn't this too big?" Then she said, her big phrase to me was, "Somehow you got music and money too intermingled."

MR: How could that possibly happen? You did what you loved man that's saying a lot.

LG: Big time.

MR: Yeah. So apparently Sammy Davis Jr. tried to fire you for having long hair?

LG: Longer hair than him. He had straight hair and it was down to like right here. Yeah that was one of my gigs at the Latin Casino that Curtis really didn't enjoy, that I loved. And plus in those days I would go smoke a reefer and come in smelling of pot and everybody knew that I did and nobody said a word because I could play the music blindfolded. I mean they loved the fact that here was this 15, 16—year—old kid who was in the union and could play better than them and grew up in Philadelphia and they were all Philadelphia musicians. Most of them were Italian. A lot of them were jazz musicians. I mean Don Renaldo, the great contractor for the Philly Sound was like Joe Venuti. He played jazz violin more than he played legitimate violin.

MR: Were there any black students when you were there? Because I know Joe Wilder and some other black musicians went there. This would have been years before you.

LG: Well how old is he?

MR: Well Joe Wilder has passed now, but this would have been in the mid—'40s.

LG: I don't even know Joe Wilder. Who is Joe Wilder?

MR: Joe Wilder is a wonderful trumpet player. And he aspired to a classical career but there was no such thing for him.

LG: Yeah. I know. I knew a Wilmer Wise. You know the name Wilmer Wise?

MR: No.

LG: Look him up. He was Leonard Bernstein's first call for like when he did his Broadway shows, you know, in that pit band he was Leonard Bernstein's first call. Brilliant violin — he was also Pablo Casals' first call in the Bach orchestra suites at Marlboro. He was a brilliant musician. I don't think he went to Curtis. When I was there there was a young man who played the clarinet named Weldon Berry who was from Philadelphia, who was a black clarinet player. And my best friend growing up was Renard Edwards who is a little older than me and still a member of the Philadelphia Orchestra. He got in the Philadelphia Orchestra at age 18, left I don't know whether he was at Curtis or he was before Curtis, but Philly Orchestra had to add a few black players and some women because they were going to lose some grants and so all of a sudden Renard came home and said, "I'm a member of the Philadelphia Orchestra." I just saw him recently and I

have to say for someone who is 80 years old he still looked brilliant and still plays and that viola is so heavy and I don't understand how he can still do it.

MR: By the way do you have trouble with alto clef with the viola?

LG: No. Not anymore. Maybe when I was like 13 or 12. No. And also, you know the cello uses musical clefs. You know that.

MR: Yeah.

LG: There's that tenor clef that we use which isn't quite the viola clef but so I was — I understood that even when I was little.

MR: All right. Well this has really been an amazing chat and I really appreciate your time today and I hope you keep on keepin' on.

LG: I will. Thank you so much.

MR: You're very welcome.

LG: Okay. Have a great day.